MODULE 12 · DOMAIN 3 - PRODUCT AND MODEL SELECTION

Choosing the Model

Haiku, Sonnet and Opus, what sits above them, and how to match capability, speed and usage to the task.

DOMAIN 3 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 12% MODULE 12 of 33

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The best model is the **smallest one that does the job well.**

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The three tiers

MODEL	STRENGTH	TRADE-OFF	REACH FOR IT WHEN
Haiku	Fastest, lightest on usage	Less depth	High volume, simple, speed-critical
Sonnet	Speed and intelligence balanced	The middle path	Everyday work: the default
Opus	Most capable of the three	Slower, heavier on usage	Complex, multi-step, high stakes

ON THE EXAM

Capability rises from Haiku to Opus. So do response time and usage.

The trade-off, in one sentence

- **More capable models generally run more slowly and use more of your limits.**
- **Lighter models are faster** and let you do far more work within the same allowance.
- **Quality only matters up to the bar the task sets.** Beyond it, you pay in time and usage for nothing.
- **Too small costs too:** rework, errors and extra review when the task really needed depth.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Choose the tier that clears the task's quality bar at the lowest cost in time and usage.

Anthropic's advice for app users

01

Start with Sonnet

The versatile default.

02

Struggling?

Step up to Opus.

03

Still struggling?

Step up again, where available.

04

Volume or speed?

Step down to Haiku.

THE TIEBREAKER

Start balanced. Step up for depth, step down for volume and speed.

Words in the question that point to a tier

TIER	SCENARIO WORDS THAT POINT TO IT
Haiku	hundreds a day, instantly, routine, classify, route, tight allowance
Sonnet	everyday, moderate volume, summaries, drafting, a balance
Opus	complex, multi-step reasoning, nuance, one-off deep analysis, speed less important

ON THE EXAM

Underline the volume, the speed and the complexity. Together they name the tier.

Choosing a model for recurring work

01

Define the need

Quality bar, latency, volume.

02

Pick candidates

Tiers that could meet it.

03

Test

On a representative sample.

04

Compare

Against the requirements.

05

Decide and monitor

Revisit as work or models change.

ON THE EXAM

Requirements come before testing. Testing uses a sample that looks like the real work.

Usage limits and model choice

- **Limits reset in rolling five-hour sessions**, with weekly caps on paid plans.
- **One shared pool** across the web, desktop and mobile apps, and Claude Code.
- **No fixed message count.** Usage depends on model, length, files, tools and thinking.
- **Heavier choices drain it faster:** Opus, the models above it, research, long files, high effort.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Matching the model to the task is also how a team stays within its limits.

Two dials: which model, and how hard it thinks

- **Dial one: the model.** Haiku, Sonnet or Opus.
- **Dial two: effort and thinking**, on models that support them.
- **Turn up** for careful reasoning; **turn down** for quick routine work.
- **Neither dial fixes a weak prompt.** Missing context stays missing at any setting.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Before changing either dial, check the prompt. A better brief often beats a bigger model.

The line-up in October 2026

- **Opus 5.5** (22 Sep), **Sonnet 5.5** (28 Sep) and **Haiku 5.5** (7 Oct): the three tiers the exam names.
- **Fable 5.1** sits above Opus: Anthropic's most capable generally available model. It uses limits fastest.
- **Mythos** is a restricted research model for vetted cyber and life-science work, not an app choice.
- **Plans differ:** Free offers Sonnet and Haiku; paid plans add Opus, and Fable on some terms.
- **Exam rule:** questions test tier logic, not version numbers.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Versions change every few months. The trade-off between the tiers does not.

One honest wrinkle: app advice and API advice

ADVICE FOR APP USERS

Start with Sonnet

- The versatile default
- Step up when it struggles
- Haiku for volume and speed

ADVICE FOR API DEVELOPERS

Start with Opus 5.5

- For most developer workloads
- Fable when evals fall short
- Tuned for building systems

THE TIEBREAKER

This is an app-user exam: match the tier to the task, start balanced, step up for depth.

Model-choice traps

THE TRAP	WHY IT FAILS
Always use the most capable model	Slower and heavier, with no gain on simple work
Always use the cheapest model	Rework and errors on tasks that needed depth
Newest is always best	Fit to the task decides, not the release date
One model for every task	Workloads differ; so should the choice
A bigger model will fix this prompt	Missing context stays missing

ON THE EXAM

Every trap replaces "what does this task need?" with a blanket rule.

> Halden's account managers want Claude to turn client meeting notes into tidy summaries, about twenty a day across the team. The summaries go to clients, so quality matters.
>
> Nobody needs them instantly, and the reasoning involved is light.

Which model best balances quality, speed and usage?

A Opus, because the summaries go to clients

B Sonnet, the balanced everyday default

C The most capable model available, to be safe

D Haiku, because the cheapest option always wins

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which model best balances quality, speed and usage?

A Opus, because the summaries go to clients

More capability than light reasoning needs, at more cost.

B Sonnet, the balanced everyday default

Good quality for client-facing summaries, moderate volume, light reasoning.

C The most capable model available, to be safe

The "biggest is safest" trap.

D Haiku, because the cheapest option always wins

A blanket rule. Quality matters here, and volume is modest.

THE SIGNAL

Moderate volume, client-facing quality, light reasoning: the balanced default.

> Halden's finance director must compare three ways to restructure the company's regional hubs. Each option interacts with leases, staff contracts and client service levels.
>
> She needs a careful, multi-step analysis by Friday. Speed of reply does not matter.

Which model is best suited?

A Haiku, to keep the analysis quick and light on usage

B Sonnet, because it is always the default

C Opus, the most capable of the three for complex reasoning

D Whichever model a colleague used last week

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which model is best suited?

A Haiku, to keep the analysis quick and light on usage

Optimises for speed she does not need, at the cost of depth she does.

B Sonnet, because it is always the default

A default is a starting point, not a rule. This task signals depth.

C Opus, the most capable of the three for complex reasoning

Complex, multi-step, one-off, and speed is not a concern.

D Whichever model a colleague used last week

Habit, not fit to the task.

THE SIGNAL

Interacting factors, multi-step reasoning, speed unimportant: step up to Opus.

> Halden's Claude champion is reviewing model choices that teams have made for five different tasks.
>
> She wants to confirm the choices that match the task well.

Which two choices are appropriate matches? Choose two.

- A Opus to tag thousands of incoming tickets by category in real time
- B Haiku for a careful, reasoned analysis of a disputed contract
- C Haiku to sort thousands of incoming tickets into categories quickly
- D Opus for a careful multi-step comparison of three restructuring options
- E The model above Opus for routine one-line replies

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two choices are appropriate matches? Choose two.

A Opus to tag thousands of incoming tickets by category in real time

High volume and real time: too slow and heavy for the job.

B Haiku for a careful, reasoned analysis of a disputed contract

Depth is the requirement; the lightest tier is the wrong fit.

C Haiku to sort thousands of incoming tickets into categories quickly

High volume, simple, speed matters: Haiku's job.

D Opus for a careful multi-step comparison of three restructuring options

Complex reasoning: Opus's job.

E The model above Opus for routine one-line replies

The heaviest model for the lightest work.

THE SIGNAL

The right pairs match tier to task in both directions: light for volume, heavy for depth.

> Halden's operations team wants Claude to draft daily updates for every client site manager, every working day, as a new recurring workflow.
>
> The team plans to test several models before choosing one.

Which step must come before testing the candidate models?

A Roll the chosen model out to every regional team

B Define the quality bar, the acceptable delay and the expected daily volume

C Monitor usage for a month to see what it costs

D Compare the test results against each other

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which step must come before testing the candidate models?

A Roll the chosen model out to every regional team

Comes after a decision, which comes after testing.

B Define the quality bar, the acceptable delay and the expected daily volume

Without requirements, test results have nothing to be judged against.

C Monitor usage for a month to see what it costs

Monitoring follows the decision.

D Compare the test results against each other

Needs results, which come from testing.

THE SIGNAL

Requirements first, then candidates, then tests on real-looking samples.

> Halden's marketing team keeps hitting its usage limits by mid-afternoon. Everyone uses Opus at maximum effort, with research mode on, for every task.
>
> Most of their tasks are short rewrites and social media captions.

What is the best change?

A Buy more seats so the team can spread the work

B Ask Anthropic for an unlimited allowance

C Match model and settings to the task: lighter models and no research for routine work, Opus kept for complex jobs

D Stop using Claude after lunch each day

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best change?

A Buy more seats so the team can spread the work

Spends money to keep wasting usage.

B Ask Anthropic for an unlimited allowance

No plan is unlimited.

C Match model and settings to the task: lighter models and no research for routine work, Opus kept for complex jobs

Removes the waste while keeping depth where it counts.

D Stop using Claude after lunch each day

Throws away half the day's value.

THE SIGNAL

Heaviest settings for the lightest tasks: the limits are a symptom of mismatched choices.

> A new Halden team leader starts using Claude for a mix of everyday drafting and planning tasks.
>
> She asks which model to use, since she has no idea which suits her work.

What is the best advice?

A Start with Sonnet, and step up to Opus for tasks where it struggles

B Start with the most capable model available, so nothing is missed

C Always use Haiku, to make the allowance last

D Test every model on every task before doing any real work

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best advice?

A Start with Sonnet, and step up to Opus for tasks where it struggles

Anthropic's own advice for app users who are unsure.

B Start with the most capable model available, so nothing is missed

Slower and heavier on limits for everyday tasks.

C Always use Haiku, to make the allowance last

A blanket rule that will fall short on harder tasks.

D Test every model on every task before doing any real work

Disproportionate for an individual's everyday work.

THE SIGNAL

Unsure, everyday work: start balanced, step up when it struggles.

> A Halden manager complains that Claude's weekly staffing summaries are vague and in the wrong format. Her prompt says only "summarise the staffing data".
>
> She plans to switch models to fix it.

What should she do first?

A Switch to Opus for the summaries

B Switch to the most powerful model her plan offers

C Turn effort up to maximum on her current model

D Improve the prompt: state the reader, purpose and required format

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should she do first?

A Switch to Opus for the summaries

A bigger model still has to guess the reader and format.

B Switch to the most powerful model her plan offers

Same problem, at greater cost.

C Turn effort up to maximum on her current model

More thinking about a task nobody described.

D Improve the prompt: state the reader, purpose and required format

Fixes the actual cause: missing context.

THE SIGNAL

Vague, wrong format, a one-line prompt: the prompt is the problem, not the model.

> Halden's customer success advisers want Claude to suggest short replies during live chats with clients. Each suggestion must appear almost instantly.
>
> The suggestions are simple, and an adviser always edits or approves them before sending.

Which model fits best?

A Opus, for the best possible suggestions

B The model above Opus, since clients are involved

C Opus with thinking turned on, to avoid mistakes

D Haiku, the fastest model

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which model fits best?

A Opus, for the best possible suggestions

Too slow for a live conversation.

B The model above Opus, since clients are involved

Slowest of all, for the simplest task.

C Opus with thinking turned on, to avoid mistakes

Slower still. The adviser already catches mistakes.

D Haiku, the fastest model

Almost instant, simple suggestions, with a human check.

THE SIGNAL

Live, almost instant, simple, and a human checks every reply: the fastest tier.

In five lines

- **Smallest model that does the job well.** Capability, speed and usage trade off.
- **Haiku** for volume and speed, **Sonnet** the everyday default, **Opus** for complex depth.
- **Unsure? Start with Sonnet**, step up when it struggles, step down for volume.
- **Recurring work:** requirements, candidates, test on real samples, compare, decide, monitor.
- **No blanket rules**, and no bigger model for a weak prompt.

> COMING UP
>
> Next: context, memory, and when to start again.